

Frege made many great contributions to the philosophy of language, however, he ran into a certain problem— a puzzle rather – known as the *puzzle of identity*. For I intend to highlight a solution, though I must first showcase the problem. Below are a pair of identity sentences involving co-referential terms – terms that both refer to the same object:

(a) *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson.*

(b) *Mike Tyson is the baddest man on the planet.*

Sentence (a) doesn't tell us anything intelligent really. No one would question if Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson (perhaps in a state of existential crisis, he himself might). So the named object is simply the named object. Yet, sentence (b) tells us something more, perhaps new, about the object. This stumped not only Frege who attempted to solve this through his idea of *sense and reference*, but Russell too, who believed that the puzzle could be solved through descriptivism – through the use of *definite descriptions*, in particular. Kripke however, offers persuasive objections against descriptivism, providing instead a “direct reference” view of how names refer. And through a Grice-inspired analysis of *assertions* of identity sentences, Stalnaker claims his findings were in line with those of Kripke. First I will show how the attempts made by Frege, Russell, and Kripke, leave the *puzzle of identity* ultimately unsolved; and then I will explicate Stalnaker's findings, which seem to offer a solution to the puzzle.

Do names and descriptions refer to objects in the same way? Put another way, does the description of a given proper name, mean that name in which it is in-fact referring to? Someone may be quick to answer ‘yes’. It seems that we do not always use the name of an object when referring to it – we sometimes use a description to sort of *jazz things up a bit*, and from this, we

assume that our audience will understand the given reference. In his paper, “On Denoting”, Russell holds a different position regarding how names refer. He states that “denoting phrases never have any meaning in themselves, but that every proposition in whose verbal expression they occur has a meaning” (*O.D.*, 480). So, Russell doesn’t believe that a description holds any weight – not until it is attached to some object and then expressed. He highlights that a description is more like that of a quantifier, e.g., *some parents*; *all animals*; *three trees*, for example – some (vague) quantity of an object is being expressed. It should be noted that the quantifier employed by Russell is fashioned in such a way as to fit one object exactly. Let’s focus our attention back to sentence (b) from above. Since definite descriptions can be replaced with quantifiers, Russell argues that the following sentence form is more appropriately expressed:

“Some x is the baddest man on the planet, and no other x is the baddest man on the planet, and x is Mike Tyson.”

Obviously, sentence (a) can be put through this same rigorous framework of Russell’s, yet it’s unnecessary for an identity sentence at this level of primitiveness to undergo such a task. What Russell’s rendering of sentence (b) tells the reader in plain English is this: *There is one person that is the baddest man on the planet and that person is Mike Tyson*. So, this framework seems to highlight that the given description denotes the given name; and not that the description *is* in-fact the name. Russell made the claim in “Knowledge by Acquaintance, and Knowledge by Description” that proper names are often disguised as definite descriptions; and this can lead to the understanding that said definite description literally means the given name. If it were true, that is to say, if the *baddest man on the planet* were to literally mean *Mike Tyson*, then we would

be forced to deal with a statement like that of sentence (a) – *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson* – a rather useless statement. Compare this with Russell’s evaluation of *Scott is the author of Waverley*, and how he argues that *the author of Waverley* doesn’t truly mean (equal) *Scott*, though the framework does reveal that someone is the *author of Waverley* and this ‘someone’ is *Scott*, who is taken to mean in particular, *Walter Scott*. Russell supports this further by saying, “when it is said that Scott is the author of Waverley, we are not stating that these are two names for one man” (*K.A.K.D.*, 126) – like in the case of *Mike Tyson is Iron Mike* (to remain consistent). Russell emphasizes that Scott needed to actually write *Waverly* in order to become the author, which he did; otherwise this would imply that people called Scott the ‘author of Waverley’ before he wrote *Waverly* (perhaps but unlikely). From this we can surmise that Mike Tyson has actually done certain things that eventually led to him earning the title of *baddest man on the planet*, which he has.

So then it seems that Russell was correct in stating, “an object is “known by description” when we know that it is “the so-and-so”, i.e., when we know that there is one object, and no more having a certain property” (*K.A.K.D.*, 113). And regarding how “we are acquainted with an object which is the so-and-so” (114), Russell has us consider this, “we know the so-and-so exists, but we may know the so-and-so exists when we are not acquainted with any object which we know to be the so-and-so” (*K.A.K.D.*, 114)”. So, (I exhaust), even though I do not know Mike Tyson – we are not acquainted – I know that there is a person that in-fact has this name. “We know that there is an object answering to a definite description though we are not acquainted with any such object” (*K.A.K.D.*, 113), says Russell. So, this view combined with his interpretation of definite descriptions, seems to provide us with a solution to the *puzzle of identity*. A name, perhaps hidden behind the use of a definite description, doesn’t literally mean

the definite description denoting it, as it may seem on the surface, but rather, it happens to be the one object that in-fact has this name and fits the description, that is the phrase denoting it. This avoids the whole “Scott is Scott” nonsense, and gives to us instead a denoting phrase, implying that the object has actually done something to earn them the stated description.

Now I would like to contrast Russell’s view using definite descriptions to solve the puzzle, with that of Frege’s view regarding *sense*. For Frege, meaning has two layers, the first being *reference* and the second being *sense*. Now I will explain how Frege would apply this view to the set of sentences above. For he, like Russell, believed that sentence (a) doesn’t express anything satisfying, nor interesting to the reader, yet he seems most curious with a sentence like sentence (b). I have restated the sentences below to help avoid confusion:

(a) *Mike Tyson is Mike Tyson.*

(b) *Mike Tyson is the baddest man on the planet.*

Frege also believes that the definite description given to the name is not literally the meaning of the name, otherwise, much like in our case with Russell, we would be guilty of turning sentence (b) into sentence (a), so then we would again have two, very plain statements, both expressing the same thing. So then how does Frege solve this problem, and how is it different from Russell? For Russell, it was introducing quantifiers in place of definite descriptions to show that a denoting phrase doesn’t literally mean the name it is referring to, but rather that there is some object that has the given name and fits the given description. It’s complicated, but it makes sense. In an attempt to put it plainly, Frege would say that the definite description, *the baddest man on the planet* is a *sense* in which the phrase is referring to some object – a person named Mike

Tyson. So the phrase isn't actually the meaning of the name. As we say in English, 'in every sense of the matter' – 'every sense' can be thought of as all the different ways to express a certain object, but that is just it: they all have to share the same referent, otherwise they cannot be considered as a sense of the referent. I will introduce another sentence, sentence (c) to hopefully strengthen the understanding:

(c) *Mike Tyson is Kid Dynamite.*

Based on what we just learned, Mike Tyson doesn't mean Kid Dynamite, but rather Kid Dynamite is a *sense* of the referent Mike Tyson. So too is the phrase *the baddest man on the planet*, a *sense* that shares Mike Tyson as a referent. To refer to Mike Tyson as *the Louisville Lip* would be to understand Frege's view of *sense* incorrectly as the true referent here would be Muhhamd Ali.

Regarding sentences with the form of (b) and (c), let us consider a few potential outcomes:

1. It may be the case that sentences (b) and (c) don't tell the reader anything new – they already know that which the sentence states.
2. Consider someone shaking hands with a person at a party who they were introduced to as *Kid Dynamite*. When asked later if they have heard of Mike Tyson, the person replies that yes they have heard of him. It is then revealed to the person that who they shook hands with earlier was in-fact Mike Tyson i.e., Kid Dynamite. The person (who would be in shock I assume) didn't know Kid Dynamite, yet they were (somewhat) aware of the

person, Mike Tyson. Now they know that these two names refer to the same object.

Consider an alternate version of the prior example, where the individual is aware of who Mike Tyson is, and what he looks like, prior to them being introduced, yet the individual is unaware that Mike Tyson is also known as the *baddest man on the planet*, or that he wore the name *Kid Dynamite* when he was younger, but perhaps maybe the individual had heard these descriptions before, so that when they were introduced to Mike Tyson, a bit of confusion rose to the surface. They learn that there are different ways that people refer to Mike Tyson, some of which the person had heard before, but never knew the referent.

Only after some sort of realization does it become clear that *Kid Dynamite*, *the baddest man on the planet*, and *Mike Tyson* all stem from the same tree – the same referent, that is Mike Tyson.

KRIPKE: “Direct Reference” view → argue the “casual” view over descriptivism

→ does no good in explaining the meaning of a name as does Russell and Frege, rather it only matters that the name which is being expressed is done so in a way that remains true to the original use of the name

USE THE NAME ADAM FOR EXAMPLE

Quotes from Kripke...

STALNAKER: look into assertions to better my understanding of how it lines up with Kripke's findings → from there adjust my thesis as necessary → yes, it seems that he has found a solution to the puzzle, but I admit I am a bit lost when reading Stalnaker, so that is where my attention has heavily turned to.

CONCLUSION: